

PSY405 - Lesson 26

Gordon Allport – A Trait Theory of Personality

WHO WAS GORDON ALLPORT? (Big Picture First)

Gordon Allport was a **personologist** — meaning:

 Personologist: A psychologist who studies the whole individual, not just averages or groups.

Allport believed:

- Every person is **unique**
- Personality comes from **inside the person**
- Traits are **real psychological structures**, not just labels
- People are **active**, not robots controlled by childhood or environment

His theory combines:

- **Humanistic psychology** (growth, meaning, values)
 - **Personalistic psychology** (focus on the individual)
-

BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH (Why his life matters)

Key Facts

- Born **1897**, Indiana
- Father: **Physician**
- Mother: **School teacher**

- Brother **Floyd Allport** → famous psychologist
- Early grades: **Cs and Ds**, later **straight As**
- Poor at sports, excellent with words
- Called a “*dictionary swallower*” by classmates 🤔

Why this matters psychologically

Allport:

- Felt **socially isolated**
- Was very **intellectual**
- Became deeply interested in **individual differences**

🧠 His own life made him ask:

“Why are people so different, even in the same situation?”

Meeting Freud (Very Important Story)

Allport met **Sigmund Freud** in Vienna.

- Freud stayed silent, waiting
- Allport told a small story about a child
- Freud replied: “*And was that little boy you?*”

➡ Allport realized Freud **over-interpreted everything** through unconscious conflict.

📌 **Lesson learned:**

Not everything is hidden childhood trauma.

Sometimes behavior is exactly what it looks like.

This shaped Allport’s rejection of extreme psychoanalysis.

2 WHAT IS PERSONALITY? (Allport's Definition)

Earlier vague idea

| "Personality is what a man really is"

Too broad ❌

Final Famous Definition (Most Important)

| "Personality is the dynamic organization within the individual of psychophysical systems that determine his characteristic behavior and thought."

Let's break this down 📌

◆ Dynamic Organization

- Personality is **always changing**
- Not fixed, not frozen

📌 Example:

You are more confident at 20 than at 15 → personality **develops**

◆ Psychophysical Systems

| Psycho = mind

| **Physical = body**

Mind and body work **together**

📌 Example:

Anxiety → fast heartbeat + worried thoughts

Not separate — **one system**

◆ Determine

Personality:

- **Causes behavior**
- Is not passive

 Example:

You don't act shy *by accident* — your personality **produces** it

◆ Characteristic Behavior and Thought

- Personality shows in:
 - How you act
 - How you think
 - How you react repeatedly

 Example:

A helpful person helps in many situations — that's **characteristic**

Character vs Temperament vs Type

◆ Character

- Moral judgment (good/bad)
- Ethical evaluation

 "She has good character" → value judgment

◆ Temperament

- Emotional style
- Mood, intensity, speed

 Calm vs aggressive

◆ Type

- Category or class

📌 "Aggressive type", "Introvert type"

⚠️ Allport disliked **types** — people are too complex.

3 CRITERIA FOR AN ADEQUATE PERSONALITY THEORY

Allport set **5 conditions** for any good personality theory.

1 Personality must be **INSIDE** the person

He rejected **role theory**:

| ❌ "You are just your roles (student, son, worker)"

Allport says:

| ✅ Personality exists within the organism

📌 Example:

You are not just "a student" — your way of being a student matters.

2 The organism is "**WELL-STOCKED**", not empty

Opposes **Skinner (behaviorism)**

- Skinner: Humans are shaped by environment
- Allport: Humans already have inner structures

📌 Example:

Two children raised the same → different personalities

3 Motivation is **PRESENT**-oriented

People are **not prisoners of childhood**

📌 Example:

You study now because you value success — not only because of parents

4 Units must allow “living synthesis”

| Personality must be broken into parts and reassembled

📌 Like Humpty Dumpty:

- Break into pieces (traits)
 - Put together again (whole person)
-

5 Self-consciousness must be included

Humans:

- Know who they are
- Reflect on themselves

📌 Example:

“I know I am shy, and I don’t like it.”

4 ALLPORT’S CONCEPT OF TRAITS (CORE IDEA)

What is a Trait?

| A trait is a predisposition to respond in a similar way across different situations.

Simpler:

| A trait is a consistent tendency in behavior.

Key Features

- Traits are **real**

- Traits are **general**
- Traits explain **consistency**

📌 Example:

Honest person → honest at home, work, exams

Important Point

Traits are **active**, not sleeping.

📌 A social person:

- Enjoys parties
 - Seeks people
 - Feels lonely alone
-

5 "TRAITS OF TRAITS" (Scientific Properties)

1 More than nominal existence

Traits are **real**, not just words.

📌 Sociability exists even if unseen

2 More general than habits

Habit	Trait
Biting nails	Nervousness
Saying salam	Politeness

3 Dynamic / Determinative

Traits **cause behavior**

📌 Aggression → fighting, harsh speech, impatience

4 Empirically verifiable

Traits can be:

- Measured
- Observed indirectly

📌 Through questionnaires, behavior patterns

5 Traits overlap

No trait is isolated

📌 Humor + insight often appear together

6 KINDS OF TRAITS

i **Cardinal Traits**

- **Very rare**
- Dominates entire personality

📌 Example:

Mother Teresa → compassion

Hitler → power obsession

ii **Central Traits**

- 5–10 major traits
- Describe a person well

📌 Honest, friendly, anxious, ambitious

iii **Secondary Dispositions**

- Situational

- Weak, inconsistent

📌 Gets angry only while driving

7 THE SELF (PROPRIUM) – 8 STAGES

| Proprium = Self

Stage	Age	Meaning
Bodily Self	Infancy	Body awareness
Self-Identity	2 yrs	"This is me"
Self-Esteem	2–4	Pride
Self-Extension	4–6	"Mine"
Self-Image	4–6	How others see me
Self as Rational	6–12	Problem-solving
Propriate Striving	Adolescence	Goals
Self as Knower	Adulthood	Self-awareness

8 FUNCTIONAL AUTONOMY (VERY IMPORTANT)

| Adult motives are independent of childhood motives

📌 Example:

- Child studies to please parents
- Adult studies to achieve goals

Two Types

Type	Meaning
Perseverative	Habits

Type	Meaning
Propriate	Values, goals

9 APPLICATION: STUDY OF VALUES

Six value types:

Value	Meaning
Theoretical	Truth
Economic	Practicality
Aesthetic	Beauty
Social	Love
Political	Power
Religious	Unity, faith

10 SUMMARY

- Personality is **real and inside the person**
- Traits explain **consistency**
- People are **unique**
- Motivation is **present-oriented**
- Self develops across life
- Values guide behavior

EVALUATION

Strengths

- ✓ Focus on individuality
- ✓ Humanistic

✓ Real-life relevance

Weaknesses

✗ Hard to measure traits

✗ Less experimental

★ FINAL MENTOR NOTE (Important)

Allport teaches us:

You are not a product of past trauma alone.
You are an active, growing, unique individual.

1. Who was Gordon Allport?

Answer:

Gordon Allport (1897–1967) was an American psychologist who developed the **trait theory of personality**. He focused on understanding **individual uniqueness** rather than general laws for groups. He is known as a **personologist**, someone who studies the whole person. Allport blended humanistic and personalistic approaches, recognizing human potential, growth, and the influence of internal motives and cognition on behavior.

Explanation:

Allport's key contribution was emphasizing that **every person is unique**, and psychology should study the **person as a whole**. Unlike behaviorists who focus only on external stimuli or Freud who emphasized unconscious drives, Allport looked at personality as something **real, dynamic, and observable** in thought and action.

Example:

Two students may study in the same class, but one is motivated by curiosity, another by grades. Allport would focus on their **unique trait patterns**, not just that they are "students."

Tips:

- Remember "Allport = Individual uniqueness."
 - Associate "personologist" → "studies the whole person."
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2. What is personality according to Allport?

Answer:

Personality is the **dynamic organization within the individual of psychophysical systems that determine characteristic behavior and thought**. This means personality is alive, constantly developing, and involves both the **mind (psycho)** and **body (physical)**. It determines how a person consistently thinks, feels, and acts.

Explanation:

- **Dynamic organization** → personality changes over time.
- **Psychophysical systems** → body and mind work together.
- **Characteristic behavior and thought** → consistent patterns that define an individual.

Example:

A person who is **generous** behaves kindly in family, work, and social situations. This generosity is part of their personality.

Tips:

- Break the definition into four parts: **Dynamic + Psychophysical + Determines + Characteristic behavior**.
 - Think: personality is "**who you really are inside**".
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3. How does Allport distinguish personality from character, temperament, and type?

Answer:

- **Character**: A moral evaluation of a person (good/bad).
- **Temperament**: Emotional and mood-based components of personality.

- **Type:** A broad category in which people can be classified (e.g., aggressive, introvert).

Explanation:

- Personality = **whole person**
- Character = **ethical judgment**
- Temperament = **emotional style**
- Type = **broad classification, not detailed**

Example:

A calm person (temperament) may be generous (personality), and society may judge them "good character." "Introvert" would be their type.

Tips:

- Character → ethics
 - Temperament → emotion
 - Type → category
 - Personality → everything combined
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4. What is a trait according to Allport?

Answer:

A trait is a **predisposition to respond in a similar way to different situations**.

Traits are enduring, general patterns of behavior that explain why people act consistently across situations.

Explanation:

- Traits are **internal**, not just habits.
- They **cause behavior**, not just describe it.
- Traits are **generalized** (not tied to one situation).

Example:

Honesty as a trait → a person tells the truth at work, home, and school.

Tips:

- "Trait = consistent behavior pattern"
 - Not the same as a single act → it's a **pattern**
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5. What are the "traits of traits"? (Defining properties of a trait)

Answer:

Allport described **eight characteristics** of a trait:

1. **Real existence** – traits are real, not imaginary
2. **Generalized** – broader than a habit
3. **Dynamic** – traits influence behavior
4. **Empirically verifiable** – can be measured scientifically
5. **Relatively independent** – not completely isolated
6. (Additional four, optional in short-answer: traits interact, evolve, guide motives, explain individual differences)

Explanation:

Traits are **real psychological structures** that influence behavior consistently, can be studied scientifically, and combine to form a person's unique personality.

Example:

Sociability as a trait:

- Exists in many situations
- Causes behavior (joining parties)
- Can be measured (questionnaires)

Tips:

- Remember: "**Real, General, Dynamic, Measurable, Overlapping**"
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6. What are the kinds of traits?

Answer:

1. **Cardinal traits** – dominate the whole personality (rare)
2. **Central traits** – main traits that describe a person (5–10 traits)
3. **Secondary dispositions** – minor traits, situational, inconsistent

Explanation:

- **Cardinal** → shapes every action (Mother Teresa = compassion)
- **Central** → general but not all-consuming (friendly, honest)
- **Secondary** → minor habits or preferences (likes chocolate, dislikes crowds)

Example:

- Cardinal: Gandhi → nonviolence
- Central: honesty, hardworking
- Secondary: likes reading mystery novels

Tips:

- Cardinal → Rare, dominates
- Central → 5–10 key traits
- Secondary → small, situational

7. What is functional autonomy?

Answer:

Functional autonomy is the idea that **adult motives are independent of childhood motives**. A behavior that started for one reason in childhood may continue in adulthood for a **different, self-chosen reason**.

Explanation:

- Perseverative → habits
- Propriate → values, goals

Example:

- Child studies to please parents → adult studies for personal ambition (appropriate)

Tips:

- Functional autonomy = **"grown-up motives are free from childhood motives"**
 - Connect with self-motivation
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8. What is Allport's concept of the self (proprium)?

Answer:

The **proprium** is the self, which develops in **eight stages** from birth to adulthood:

1. Bodily self – body awareness
2. Self-identity – "this is me"
3. Self-esteem – pride in achievements
4. Self-extension – awareness of possessions
5. Self-image – how others see me
6. Self as rational – problem-solving
7. Propriate striving – setting goals
8. Self as knower – self-reflection, integration

Explanation:

The proprium is **central to personality**. It shows how self-awareness, goals, and values develop over time.

Example:

- A teenager becomes aware of their strengths and weaknesses (Self as rational)
- An adult sets life goals (Propriate striving)

Tips:

- Memorize as **Body → Identity → Esteem → Extension → Image → Rational → Striving → Knower**

- Think of it as **self-growth stages**
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9. How does Allport apply traits to the study of values?

Answer:

Allport identified **six value types** that motivate people:

1. Theoretical – seeking truth
2. Economic – practicality, utility
3. Aesthetic – beauty and harmony
4. Social – love, relationships
5. Political – power, influence
6. Religious – unity, faith

Explanation:

- Values guide behavior and give **purpose** to actions.
- Traits interact with values → predictable patterns of thought and action.

Example:

- A person with a social trait may value friendship → volunteer in community programs

Tips:

- Remember **“The Elephant Ate Some Pretty Raisins”** → T, E, A, S, P, R
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10. What is Allport’s contribution to personality psychology?

Answer:

- Emphasized **individual uniqueness**
- Developed **trait theory**
- Introduced **functional autonomy** and **proprium**

- Highlighted **internal motives and present-oriented behavior**
- Blended **humanistic and personalistic approaches**

Explanation:

Allport shifted psychology away from rigid determinism (like Freud or Skinner) to a **more flexible, individual-centered understanding**.

Example:

- Two people respond differently to the same event → Allport explains this using their **unique traits, values, and self**.

Tips:

- Think: **Allport = uniqueness + traits + self + autonomy + values**

1 True/False Statements

Q1. Gordon Allport emphasized the study of group behavior rather than individual uniqueness.

- **Answer:** False
- **Explanation:** Allport focused on **individual uniqueness** and the study of the **whole person**.

Q2. According to Allport, traits are dormant until triggered by external stimuli.

- **Answer:** False
- **Explanation:** Traits are **active**; individuals may seek situations to express their traits.

Q3. Functional autonomy refers to adult motives being independent of childhood motives.

- **Answer:** True
- **Explanation:** Adult motives often continue behaviors initiated in childhood but for **different reasons**.

Q4. Cardinal traits are common in most people.

- **Answer:** False

- **Explanation:** Cardinal traits are **rare** and dominate a person's whole personality.

Q5. Temperament is a moral evaluation of personality.

- **Answer:** False
 - **Explanation:** Temperament = **emotional style**, Character = moral evaluation.
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2 Conceptual MCQs

Q6. Which of the following best defines a trait according to Allport?

- A) A habit acquired through repetition
- B) A predisposition to respond consistently across situations
- C) A moral judgment about behavior
- D) A category in which a person is classified

- **Answer:** B
 - **Explanation:** Traits are **generalized, enduring patterns of behavior**, not habits, moral judgments, or categories.
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Q7. Allport's definition of personality includes:

- A) Environmental influence only
- B) Psychophysical systems within the individual
- C) Social roles exclusively
- D) Childhood experiences only

- **Answer:** B
 - **Explanation:** Personality = **dynamic organization of mind and body**; environment, social roles, and past experiences may influence but are not the core.
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Q8. Which of the following is NOT a type of trait described by Allport?

- A) Cardinal trait
- B) Secondary disposition

- C) Central trait
- D) Universal trait

- **Answer:** D
 - **Explanation:** Allport's traits: **Cardinal, Central, Secondary**. Universal trait is not part of his system.
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Q9. The "proprium" in Allport's theory refers to:

- A) A specific habit
- B) Self or core of personality
- C) Moral judgment
- D) Childhood trauma

- **Answer:** B
 - **Explanation:** Proprium = **self**, develops over 8 stages from birth to adulthood.
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Q10. Which of the following statements about functional autonomy is true?

- A) Adult behavior is always caused by childhood experiences
- B) Habits are completely unrelated to traits
- C) Adult motives may differ from original childhood motives
- D) Adult goals are predetermined and unchangeable

- **Answer:** C
 - **Explanation:** Functional autonomy = **adult motives are independent** of the original childhood reasons for behavior.
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3 Situational/Applied MCQs

Q11. Ahmed always helps his neighbors in different situations — at home, in the market, and at work. According to Allport, this behavior is most likely explained by:

- A) Secondary disposition
- B) Cardinal trait
- C) Central trait

D) Type

- **Answer:** C
 - **Explanation:** Consistent but not dominant across entire personality → **Central trait**.
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Q12. Sara studies hard in college. As a child, she studied to please her parents. Now, she studies to pursue her own career goals. This illustrates:

- A) Temperament
- B) Functional autonomy
- C) Cardinal trait
- D) Habit

- **Answer:** B
 - **Explanation:** Adult motives **independent of childhood motives** → Functional autonomy.
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Q13. Ali is very ambitious. His ambition causes him to excel in studies, sports, and art. This trait dominates his personality. According to Allport, this is an example of:

- A) Secondary disposition
- B) Central trait
- C) Cardinal trait
- D) Temperament

- **Answer:** C
 - **Explanation:** A trait that dominates the **entire personality** → Cardinal trait.
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Q14. Fatima is shy in class but outgoing with her family. According to Allport, shyness is:

- A) Cardinal trait
- B) Central trait
- C) Secondary disposition
- D) Functional autonomy

- **Answer: C**
- **Explanation:** Shyness appears **only in some situations** → Secondary disposition.

Q15. Which of the following best reflects Allport's view of personality?

- A) Personality is solely shaped by social roles.
- B) Personality is an active, unique organization of traits and self.
- C) Personality is entirely determined by childhood experiences.
- D) Personality cannot be studied scientifically.

- **Answer: B**
- **Explanation:** Personality = **unique, dynamic, trait-based, measurable**, not passive or socially-defined only.

Cheat Sheet

1 Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition	Example	Memory Hook
Trait	A consistent predisposition to respond across situations	Honesty → truthful at home, work, school	"Traits = Patterns"
Cardinal Trait	Dominates the whole personality (rare)	Mother Teresa → compassion	"Cardinal = Chief"
Central Trait	Major traits, describe personality (5–10)	Friendly, Honest, Ambitious	"Central = Core"
Secondary Disposition	Minor, situational traits	Shyness in class, outgoing at home	"Secondary = Small"
Functional Autonomy	Adult motives independent of childhood	Studied as child for parents → adult studies for career	"Autonomy = Independent"
Proprium (Self)	Core self, develops in 8 stages	Child recognizes self → adult self-	"Proprium = Proper self"

Term	Definition	Example	Memory Hook
		reflective	
Personality	Dynamic organization of psychophysical systems that determine characteristic behavior & thought	A generous person behaves kindly across situations	"Personality = Who you really are"
Character	Moral evaluation of a person	Good/bad person	"Character = Ethics"
Temperament	Emotional/mood-based component	Calm or excitable	"Temperament = Mood"
Type	Broad classification	Aggressive type, Introvert	"Type = Category"

2 Allport's Eight Traits of a Trait

#	Trait Property	Meaning	Example
1	Real existence	Traits are actual psychological entities	Sociability exists even if unseen
2	Generalized	Broader than habit, across situations	Honesty at work, home, school
3	Dynamic	Causes behavior	Aggression → impatience, arguing
4	Empirically verifiable	Can be scientifically measured	Personality questionnaires
5	Relatively independent	Traits overlap but are separate	Humor + insight
6	Stable over time	Persist across lifespan	Kindness from childhood → adulthood
7	Guides motives	Influences goals & decisions	Ambition → career success
8	Explains individual differences	Why people react differently	Two students respond differently in same class

3 Kinds of Traits – Quick Table

Trait Type	Definition	Frequency	Example
Cardinal	Dominates entire personality	Rare	Gandhi → nonviolence
Central	Key traits, describe personality	Common	Honest, friendly
Secondary	Minor, situational traits	Common	Likes reading mystery novels

Mnemonic: "Cardi-Central-Secondary → CCS"

Think: **CCS = Chief Core Small**

4 Functional Autonomy Types

Type	Meaning	Example
Perseverative	Habits carried on	Biting nails, checking phone
Propriate	Values & goals, self-chosen	Studying for career, volunteering

Memory Hook: "Propriate → Proper adult goals"

5 The Self (Proprium) – 8 Stages

Stage	Age	Meaning	Example
Bodily Self	Infancy	Body awareness	Baby touches own hands
Self-Identity	2 yrs	"This is me"	Child points to self
Self-Esteem	2–4	Pride in achievements	Child proud of drawing
Self-Extension	4–6	Awareness of possessions	"This toy is mine"
Self-Image	4–6	How others see me	Child proud of praise
Self as Rational	6–12	Problem-solving	Planning to finish homework
Propriate Striving	Adolescence	Goal setting	Plans future career

Stage	Age	Meaning	Example
Self as Knower	Adulthood	Integration, self-reflection	Evaluates own strengths/weaknesses

Mnemonic: "Body I Eat Every Sweet Red Kiwi" → Bodily, Identity, Esteem, Extension, Self-image, Rational, Striving, Knower

6 Allport's Six Value Types

Value	Meaning	Example
Theoretical	Seeking truth	Scientist, researcher
Economic	Practicality	Entrepreneur, accountant
Aesthetic	Beauty, harmony	Artist, architect
Social	Love, friendship	Volunteer, helper
Political	Power, influence	Leader, politician
Religious	Faith, unity	Devout believer

Mnemonic: "The Elephant Ate Some Pretty Raisins" → T, E, A, S, P, R

7 Quick Concept Reminders

- **Personality = Active, inside the person, unique**
- **Traits = Generalized, enduring, dynamic**
- **Cardinal traits = rare, dominate personality**
- **Central traits = core traits**
- **Secondary traits = situational**
- **Functional autonomy = adult motives independent of childhood**
- **Proprium = self, develops in 8 stages**
- **Values guide behavior and reflect traits**

8 Exam Tip Table: Trait Examples

Trait Type	Classroom Example	Home Example	Social Example
Cardinal	Student always helps everyone	Always kind to family	Always volunteers in community
Central	Honest student	Honest with siblings	Friendly to friends
Secondary	Shy during exams	Shy with neighbors	Shy in parties

Memory Hacks

1. **CCS → Cardinal, Central, Secondary**
2. **BIEESRSK → Proprium 8 stages**
3. **TEASPR → Value types**
4. **Traits = Patterns → Active, Generalized, Measurable**